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LOSING WEIGHT VS. LOSING FAT

HOW TO PROTECT YOUR MUSCLE WHILE DROPPING POUNDS

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Before You Read

Educational information only. Not medical advice. This paper explains what public health agencies and published research say about losing fat while keeping your muscle. It does not diagnose, treat, or promise any result. Talk with your doctor before you change how you eat or exercise, **especially if you have a health condition, an injury, or take medication** (including weight-loss medication).

How to use this paper:

- **Short on time?** Read **The 60-Second Version** below, then jump to **Your Starter Week** and the **At a Glance** page.
- **Heard something at the gym?** Go to **Myth vs. Fact**. Every claim gets a verdict.
- **Want to check our work?** Every fact has a small bracket like this: [1]. Match it to the numbered **References** at the end. Every source is public and checkable.

Our verdict scale:

Verdict	What it means
True	The evidence clearly supports the claim.
Misleading	Has a grain of truth, but leads people to the wrong conclusion.
It's complicated	The honest answer depends on the details.
False	The evidence does not support the claim.

How strong is the evidence? We tell you that too:

- **Randomized trials** split people into groups by chance and change one thing. They are the best way to show cause and effect. Many in this paper are small or short.
- **Meta-analyses and systematic reviews** pool many studies together. They give a bigger, steadier picture.
- **Observational studies** follow large groups of people and look for patterns. They can show two things are **linked**. They can't prove one **causes** the other.
- **Position stands and guidelines** are summaries written by expert groups and government agencies after reviewing the research.

The 60-Second Version

- **Weight is not the same as fat.** When you lose weight, you lose some mix of fat, water, stored carbs (glycogen), and lean tissue, which includes muscle [1][2].
- **The fast drop in week one is not all fat.** Stored carbs are packed with about 3 to 4 parts water. When those stores shrink, the water goes too [1].
- **Muscle matters more for what it does than what it burns.** At rest, a pound of muscle burns only about 6 calories a day. A pound of fat burns about 2 [3].
- **Strength training is the #1 signal to keep muscle.** In 6 trials of older adults with obesity who cut calories, adding strength training reduced lean-mass loss by **93.5%** [4].
- **Walking is great. It just isn't the whole plan.** Federal guidelines say adults need aerobic activity **and** muscle-strengthening activity on **2 or more days a week** [5]. Only about **1 in 4** U.S. adults meets both [6].
- **Protein helps.** Eating more than the basic protein minimum during weight loss helps people keep more lean mass [7][8].
- **Slow down.** Faster weight loss tends to cost more lean mass [9][10].
- **Sleep counts.** In a small 2-week study, cutting sleep while dieting shifted weight loss away from fat and toward lean mass [11].
- **Track more than the scale:** waist, strength, steps, and energy [12][13].

Introduction: The Scale Moment

By Jesse "No Excuses Jesse" Collins | LoadLine Fitness & Wellness

You step on the scale.

You're down five pounds.

You feel good. Your clothes fit better. You're excited because the number is finally moving in the right direction.

But here's a question most people never stop to ask:

How much of that weight was actually body fat?

Because losing weight and losing fat are not exactly the same thing.

When you lose weight, you may lose body fat, water, stored carbohydrates, and sometimes muscle.

And while losing excess body fat can improve your health, losing more muscle than necessary may make it harder to stay strong, stay active, and support your long-term fitness.

At LoadLine Fitness & Wellness, our philosophy is simple:

Don't just chase a smaller number. Build a healthier, stronger body you can maintain.

Let's break down what happens during weight loss and how to protect the muscle you've worked to build.

1. The Scale Doesn't Tell the Whole Story

Your bathroom scale measures total body weight.

It doesn't tell the difference between fat, muscle, water, or anything else in your body.

When you start eating fewer calories, especially if you also cut back on carbohydrates, you may see a fast drop in weight.

Part of that early drop comes from **glycogen and water**.

Glycogen is the stored form of carbohydrate. It lives mostly in your muscles and liver. Your body stores it with about **3 to 4 parts water** for every part glycogen [1]. When glycogen stores shrink, that water leaves too.

That's why your scale can move quickly in the first few days of a diet. It's also why the scale can jump back up after a big, carb-heavy meal [1].

But that doesn't mean every pound you lose is body fat.

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS: THE "ONE-QUARTER RULE"

You may hear that about **one-fourth** of the weight you lose by dieting is lean mass, and three-fourths is fat. That's a real, widely cited rule of thumb. But when scientists reviewed it in 2014, they found the true share **changes** [2]:

- It's **bigger in the first days and weeks** of a diet, when glycogen, water, and some protein come off fast.
- People who start with **more body fat** tend to lose a **smaller** share as lean mass.
- Exercise, age, and inactivity all move the number.
- "Lean mass" (also called fat-free mass) is **not just muscle**. It also includes water, glycogen, organs, and bone minerals.

Bottom line: One-quarter is a rough average, not a law. Your habits can change your number.

The LoadLine lesson: Don't judge your progress by one weigh-in. Look at weight trends, waist measurements, strength, and how you feel over time.

2. Why Losing Muscle During Weight Loss Matters

Muscle isn't just about looking athletic or having bigger arms.

Your skeletal muscles help you:

- Walk, climb stairs, and keep your balance.
- Lift groceries and handle everyday tasks.
- Stay strong and independent as you age.
- Use and store glucose (sugar) from your bloodstream. Skeletal muscle is responsible for about **80%** of the glucose taken up from the blood after a meal [14].
- Exercise and enjoy physical activities.

Muscle is also metabolically active tissue.

But here's an important truth: **muscle doesn't burn huge amounts of calories while you're resting.**

13 vs. 4.5

Calories burned at rest, per kilogram per day: skeletal muscle vs. fat tissue. That's only about 6 calories per pound of muscle vs. about 2 per pound of fat. Organs like your heart, kidneys, liver, and brain burn far more per pound [3].

Here's the math. If you added 5 pounds of muscle, you'd burn roughly 20 more calories a day at rest than if those 5 pounds were fat. That's real, but it's small.

So preserving muscle is valuable, but not because every extra pound cranks up your metabolism.

The bigger benefits are strength, physical capacity, and the ability to stay active. Large studies link muscle-strengthening activity with a **10% to 17% lower risk** of early death, heart disease, cancer, and diabetes [15]. Those are observational studies, so they show a link, not proof of cause. But the pattern is consistent.

Think about it.

If you're losing weight but becoming noticeably weaker, struggling with things that used to be easy, or constantly feeling wiped out, it's worth reviewing your nutrition, training, and recovery.

Here's some good news: research shows weight loss usually **improves** how well people move, mostly because they carry less fat. And strength training is what builds strength while you lose [16].

The goal is to lose excess fat while keeping as much useful muscle and strength as you reasonably can.

3. Walking Is Excellent, But It Doesn't Replace Strength Training

If you've followed my personal journey, you already know that walking is a major part of my daily routine. I'm a strong believer in walking because it's easy to start, practical, and easier to fit into a busy schedule than many people realize.

Here's what the research says walking can do:

- **Fitness and endurance.** Brisk walking counts as moderate-intensity aerobic activity, the kind the federal guidelines recommend [5].
- **Long-term health.** In a study of more than 47,000 adults, people who took more steps per day had a lower risk of death. The benefit leveled off around **6,000 to 8,000 steps** a day for adults 60 and older, and around **8,000 to 10,000** for younger adults [17].
- **Blood sugar after meals.** In short lab studies, breaking up long sitting with light walking lowered the rise in blood sugar after meals better than sitting or standing [18].
- **More daily energy use.** Moving more means burning more energy across the day [5].

1 in 4

U.S. adults met the guidelines for both aerobic and muscle-strengthening activity in 2020 (24.2%). About 31% met the strength guideline at all [6].

But walking and resistance training create **different** results.

Walking uses lots of repeated, low-force muscle contractions.

Resistance training challenges your muscles to produce **more force** against a load. That challenge is an important signal for keeping muscle. The federal guidelines say muscle-strengthening activities "can also help maintain muscle mass during weight loss" [5].

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS: WALKING VS. LIFTING WHILE DIETING

A 2017 trial in the *New England Journal of Medicine* put 160 older adults with obesity on a weight-loss program for 6 months. They were split into aerobic exercise, resistance training, or both [19].

- All three exercise groups lost about **9%** of their body weight.
- Lean mass dropped about **5%** in the aerobic-only group, but only about **2% to 3%** in the groups that lifted.
- Strength rose about **18% to 19%** in the lifting groups, but only about **4%** with aerobic exercise alone.
- The **combined** group (aerobic + strength) improved physical function the most.

Bottom line: Walking helps. Walking **plus** strength training wins.

The key isn't choosing between walking and strength training. It's understanding why both matter.

Walking supports your activity and endurance.

Strength training helps preserve your muscle and physical capacity.

Together, they can form a stronger foundation for sustainable weight management.

A simple walking tool: Our free **Walkingout** app plans short walks around the day you already have: your wake-up, work, lunch, breaks, and bedtime. Then it spreads your step goal across those walks. No account. No login. It runs in your phone's browser. Try it at www.loadlinefitness.com/apps/walkingout/.

4. What Happens When You Diet Without Strength Training?

Imagine two people who each want to lose 25 pounds. *(This is an example to explain the idea, not a promise or a prediction.)*

Both reduce their calorie intake and increase their daily walking.

Person A doesn't do any resistance training.

Person B walks, does regular resistance training, and eats enough protein.

Both people may lose weight.

But Person B is giving the body a stronger signal to keep muscle.

That doesn't guarantee Person B will keep every ounce of muscle. And it doesn't mean Person A will lose a lot of muscle.

Their results also depend on age, starting body composition, how big the calorie deficit is, protein intake, genetics, and other factors [2].

However, research consistently supports resistance training as an effective way to preserve muscle and strength during weight loss [4][16][19].

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS: PERSON A VS. PERSON B IN REAL STUDIES

- **Diet alone vs. diet + exercise.** A review of 52 studies of middle-aged and older adults found that **81%** of diet-only groups lost 15% or more of their weight as lean (fat-free) mass. With exercise added (mostly aerobic), that dropped to **39%** of groups [20].
- **Adding strength training.** A meta-analysis of 6 randomized trials in older adults with obesity found that strength training **3 times a week** reduced diet-related lean-mass loss by **93.5%**. Fat loss and weight loss were about the same with or without lifting [4].
- **One honest catch.** Strength training doesn't make the scale drop faster. The American College of Sports Medicine says resistance training "does not enhance weight loss," but it may increase fat-free mass and fat loss [21].

Two people can lose the same amount of weight and still finish with different body compositions and strength levels.

That's why the **quality** of weight loss matters, not just the **quantity**.

5. Five Strength Exercises You Can Start at Home

You don't need an expensive gym membership or complicated equipment.

A resistance band, a kettlebell, a pair of dumbbells, or your own body weight can be a useful starting point. Here are five exercises to consider. Together they train your legs, hips, back, chest, shoulders, arms, and core. That lines up with the federal advice to work "all major muscle groups" [5][22].

Safety first: Move slowly and with control. Stop if you feel sharp pain, dizziness, or chest discomfort. If you have an injury, joint problem, or health condition, ask your doctor or a physical therapist which moves are right for you.

Exercise 1: Chair Squats

How: Sit down on a sturdy chair and stand back up with control. Feet about hip-width apart. Push through your whole foot.

Trains: Legs and hips, the muscles you use to get up from a chair, a car, or the floor.

Easier: Use a higher seat or hold a counter for support.

Harder: Use a lower seat, pause just above the chair, or hold a dumbbell or kettlebell at your chest.

Exercise 2: Resistance Band Rows

How: Secure a band to a solid anchor, like a door anchor in a closed door. Pull the handles toward your ribs, squeeze your shoulder blades, and return slowly.

Trains: Upper back and arms.

Easier: Step closer to the anchor or use a lighter band.

Harder: Step back, use a heavier band, or do one-arm dumbbell rows with a hand on a bench.

Always check that the anchor is secure before you pull.

Exercise 3: Wall or Incline Push-Ups

How: Place your hands on a stable wall, counter, or sturdy table. Keep your body in a straight line. Lower your chest toward your hands, then push away.

Trains: Chest, shoulders, and the backs of your arms.

Easier: Stand closer to the wall.

Harder: Move to a lower surface, like a counter, then a sturdy bench, then the floor.

Exercise 4: Hip Hinges

How: Stand with feet about hip-width apart. Push your hips **back**, like you're closing a car door with your rear end. Keep your back flat and a soft bend in your knees. Then stand tall and squeeze your glutes.

Trains: Glutes, hamstrings, and lower back (your "posterior chain").

Easier: Bodyweight only, hands on your hips, or touch a wall behind you with your hips.

Harder: Hold a kettlebell or a pair of dumbbells and lower them along your legs (a "deadlift" pattern).

Exercise 5: Loaded Carries

How: Hold a kettlebell, dumbbell, or heavy grocery bag at your side (or one in each hand). Stand tall and walk with control.

Trains: Grip, core, shoulders, and posture.

Easier: Lighter weight, shorter distance, or a weight in each hand.

Harder: Heavier weight, longer walk, or one side only ("suitcase carry") to challenge your core more.

How Often Should You Train?

For most generally healthy adults, the federal guideline is **muscle-strengthening activity that works all the major muscle groups on 2 or more days a week** [5][22]. Older adults should also add **balance** training [5].

If you're new to strength training, start easy.

A simple first session might be **one or two sets** of each exercise, with a weight or band you can control for about **8 to 12 reps**. That rep range is what the American College of Sports Medicine suggests for beginners [23].

As you get stronger, slowly raise the challenge.

This is called **progressive overload** [23].

You don't have to lift heavier every session. Progress can also mean better form, more reps, a slower lowering phase, a heavier band, or an extra set.

A simple progression rule: When you can do **1 or 2 more reps** than your target with good form, make it a little harder next time. ACSM suggests raising the load about **2% to 10%** at that point [23]. With bands, step back or go up one band.

The goal is to build a routine you can repeat consistently.

6. Protein Helps Protect Your Muscle

Resistance training provides the challenge.

Protein supplies the amino acids your body uses to repair and maintain muscle tissue.

When you're eating fewer calories, getting enough protein matters even more.

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS: PROTEIN WHILE LOSING WEIGHT

- **More than the minimum helps during a calorie deficit.** The basic protein RDA is **0.8 grams per kilogram** of body weight a day. A 2020 meta-analysis found that eating **more than the RDA** helped people keep more lean mass while cutting calories. In everyday life with no diet and no training, the RDA was enough [7].
- **Older adults kept more lean mass.** In adults over 50, higher-protein weight-loss diets helped people keep more lean mass and lose more fat [8].
- **Ranges used in research.** A review of protein and weight loss described diets with **1.2 to 1.6 g/kg a day**, and about **25 to 30 grams per meal**, as helpful for appetite and weight management [24]. Experts on aging suggest at least **1.0 to 1.2 g/kg** for healthy adults over 65, and **1.2 g/kg or more** for those who exercise [25].
- **More isn't always better.** For people lifting weights, extra protein stopped adding muscle gains above about **1.6 g/kg a day** [26]. A 4-week study of young men in a very large calorie deficit, training hard 6 days a week, found 2.4 g/kg beat 1.2 g/kg for lean mass [27], but that was a short, extreme setup, not everyday life.
- **Pooled trials:** Higher-protein diets with the same calories helped people keep about **0.4 kg** (about 1 pound) more fat-free mass on average [28].

What this means in pounds: 1.2 to 1.6 g/kg is about **0.55 to 0.73 grams per pound** of body weight. These are ranges from research, not a personal target. Your number depends on your size, age, activity, and health. A registered dietitian or your doctor can help you find yours.

Useful protein sources include:

- Eggs
- Fish and seafood
- Chicken and turkey
- Lean meats

- Greek yogurt and cottage cheese
- Beans, lentils, tofu, and other plant proteins

Spreading protein across your meals, instead of saving it all for dinner, is a simple habit that lines up with the research above [24].

Protein supplements can also be convenient when they help you meet your needs.

But remember, **protein powder is a tool, not a requirement.**

Your ideal daily protein intake depends on things like body size, age, activity level, health status, and goals.

People with certain medical conditions, **including kidney disease**, may need different guidance. Kidney nutrition guidelines give people with chronic kidney disease their own protein advice [29]. If that's you, talk to your doctor or a kidney dietitian before you change your protein.

Protein and resistance training work together. Neither one is a magic solution. A major review put it this way: aim for "adequate (but not excessive)" protein along with more physical activity, especially resistance exercise [16].

7. Stop Trying to Lose Weight as Fast as Possible

One of the biggest mistakes people make is assuming faster weight loss always means better progress.

They slash calories.

They pile on exercise.

They skip recovery.

And they expect their bodies to perform at the same level while getting much less energy.

Very aggressive dieting can make it harder to train well, recover, and keep lean tissue.

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS: FAST VS. SLOW

- **Same weight lost, different results.** In a 2017 randomized trial, 42 adults lost at least 5% of their weight either fast (in 5 weeks) or slow (in 15 weeks). The fast group lost more lean mass and body water. The slow group lost more fat and more off the waist [9].
- **Another trial agrees.** In a 2016 study, people who lost weight on a very-low-calorie diet over 5 weeks lost a bigger share of fat-free mass than those who lost a similar amount over 12 weeks on a more moderate diet. Weight regain later was about the same in both groups. But across everyone, people who lost more fat-free mass tended to regain more [10].
- **Small studies, same direction.** These trials are small, so we keep the claim modest: faster isn't automatically better for body composition.

A more moderate, sustainable approach is often a better starting point.

The right pace is different for everyone. It depends on your starting point, your health, and your treatment plan. Your doctor can help you set it.

Don't turn weight loss into a competition to see who can eat the least.

Progress, not punishment.

8. Sleep and Recovery Are Part of the Program

You can have a solid workout plan and a reasonable nutrition strategy, but poor recovery can still make the process harder.

Sleep supports physical recovery, training performance, appetite, and overall health.

Sleep experts recommend that adults sleep **7 or more hours per night** on a regular basis. (That consensus covers adults ages 18 to 60. Individual needs vary.) [30]

+60%

More lean (fat-free) mass lost when dieters had 5.5 hours in bed instead of 8.5. Weight loss was similar, but the short-sleep phase lost 55% less fat. Small study: 10 adults, 2 weeks each [11].

A larger 8-week study found something similar. Cutting about **1 hour** of sleep on 5 nights a week meant a smaller share of the weight lost came from fat. "Catch-up" sleep on the other nights may not fully fix it [31].

If you're sleeping poorly over and over, don't assume more exercise is the answer.

Sometimes the better move is to fix your schedule, get help for sleep problems, or ease off training for a bit.

At LoadLine, recovery isn't optional.
It's part of building a routine that lasts.

9. Track More Than Your Body Weight

Your scale is useful, but it shouldn't be your only measure of progress.

Here are five things worth tracking.

- 1. Weight trends:** Compare over weeks instead of reacting to daily ups and downs. Research links regular self-weighing with more weight loss, and it was not linked to depression or anxiety in those studies [32].
- 2. Waist circumference:** A tape measure tells you something the scale can't. Experts call waist size a "vital sign" because it adds information beyond BMI [12]. Measure the same way every time (see the steps below).
- 3. Strength:** Can you do more reps, use more resistance, or move with better control?
- 4. Daily movement:** Are you staying active through the day? Steps are an easy number to watch [17].
- 5. Energy and recovery:** Are you sleeping enough and feeling capable of everyday activities?

How to measure your waist (NIH method): Stand up. Place a tape measure around your middle, **just above your hipbones**. Measure **just after you breathe out** [13]. Same time of day, same tape, snug but not squeezing.

About body-fat scales and gadgets: Body-composition numbers can be interesting, but treat them with care. A 2021 study tested three smart scales against a hospital DXA scan. The scales measured **weight** well, but their typical (median) errors for fat and muscle were about **2 to 4.5 kilograms** (about 5 to 10 pounds). The authors concluded smart scales "are not accurate for body composition" [33]. European clinical nutrition experts also warn that these devices are less reliable when your hydration is off, and that changes over time "must be interpreted with caution" [34].

Look for patterns across several measurements instead of trusting one number.

10. The LoadLine Approach: Train, Move, Recover, Track, Repeat

At LoadLine Fitness & Wellness, we believe long-term progress comes from habits you can maintain. Our approach combines five principles.

	The principle	What it looks like
TRAIN	Challenge your muscles with resistance exercises that fit your ability.	2+ strength days a week [5]
MOVE	Walk, cycle, swim, or choose activities that keep you physically active.	Daily walks; try Walkingout
RECOVER	Prioritize sleep, hydration, and rest.	7+ hours of sleep as a goal [30]
TRACK	Measure meaningful progress beyond the bathroom scale.	Weight trend, waist, strength, steps
REPEAT	Build a routine you can follow even when life isn't perfect.	Same plan, small upgrades

You don't need a flawless week.

You need a system that helps you return to your habits when your schedule gets busy, your motivation changes, or progress slows.

Consistency beats perfection.

A Note on Weight-Loss Medications

Some people lose weight with help from prescription medicines, such as GLP-1 medications. This paper does **not** give any advice about medications.

But it's worth knowing that the same muscle message shows up there too:

- A 2025 joint advisory from four nutrition and obesity medicine groups lists **preserving muscle and bone mass through resistance training and appropriate diet** as a priority during GLP-1 treatment [35].
- A 2024 review found that how much lean mass people lose on these medicines **varies a lot from study to study**. It also notes that "lean mass" includes organs, bone, and water, not just muscle [36].

If you take a weight-loss medication, talk to your prescriber about strength training, protein, and how to keep your muscle. They know your health history. We don't.

Myth vs. Fact

Nine things people say about weight loss and muscle. Here's what the evidence shows.

Myth #1: "Muscle burns tons of calories at rest."

VERDICT: MISLEADING

What the evidence says: Skeletal muscle burns about **13 calories per kilogram per day** at rest. Fat burns about **4.5** [3]. That's about 6 vs. 2 calories per pound. Adding a few pounds of muscle changes your resting burn by a small amount.

The grain of truth: Muscle does burn more than fat. And in diet studies, keeping more lean mass went along with a smaller drop in resting energy use [28].

Bottom line: Build muscle for strength, function, and health. Not because it's a furnace.

Myth #2: "Walking alone will keep your muscle while you diet."

VERDICT: MISLEADING

What the evidence says: Exercise of any kind helps. In one review, adding exercise (mostly aerobic) cut the share of diet groups with big lean-mass losses from 81% to 39% [20]. Endurance exercise helps preserve muscle mass, too [16]. But in a head-to-head trial, people who lifted lost **less lean mass** (2% to 3% vs. 5%) and gained **much more strength** than people who did aerobic exercise alone [19].

Bottom line: Keep walking. Add strength training at least 2 days a week [5].

Myth #3: "High-protein diets will hurt healthy kidneys."

VERDICT: FALSE (for healthy adults)

What the evidence says: A 2018 meta-analysis of 28 studies (1,358 people) compared higher-protein diets (at least 1.5 g/kg a day, or 20% of calories, or 100 g a day) with normal or lower protein. Kidney function changes were **no different** in healthy adults [37].

The important exception: People who already have kidney disease may need to limit protein. They should follow their doctor's plan [25][29].

Bottom line: If your kidneys are healthy, a higher-protein diet hasn't been shown to harm them. If you have kidney disease, ask your care team first.

Myth #4: "You can't build muscle after 50."

VERDICT: FALSE

What the evidence says: A meta-analysis of 49 studies of adults 50 and older found strength training added about **1.1 kg** (about 2.4 pounds) of lean mass on average [38]. In a classic 1990 study, frail nursing-home residents around age 90 (up to 96) did 8 weeks of strength training. The 9 who finished **gained 174% in strength** on average and built thigh muscle [39].

The grain of truth: Older adults may gain a bit less than younger people. Higher-volume programs tend to work better [38].

Bottom line: It's never too late to start. The National Strength and Conditioning Association calls strength training "a powerful intervention" for older adults [40].

Myth #5: "That 5-pound drop in week one was all fat."

VERDICT: FALSE

What the evidence says: Much of the early drop is glycogen and the water stored with it, about 3 to 4 parts water per part glycogen [1]. The share of weight lost as lean mass is also **highest in the first days and weeks** of dieting [2].

Bottom line: Celebrate the start. Judge your progress over weeks, not days.

Myth #6: "The faster you lose, the better."

VERDICT: MISLEADING

What the evidence says: In two randomized trials, people who lost the same amount of weight faster lost more lean mass [9][10].

The grain of truth: Fast weight loss can feel motivating. In one of those trials, it also improved some blood test results more [9]. But for keeping muscle, slower looked better.

Bottom line: Pick a pace you can live with. Let your doctor help you set it.

Myth #7: "Strength training makes the scale drop faster."

VERDICT: FALSE

What the evidence says: The American College of Sports Medicine says resistance training "does not enhance weight loss" [21]. In the meta-analysis of older adults, weight loss was about the same with or without lifting. The difference was **what** was lost [4].

Bottom line: Lift to keep muscle and get stronger. Don't judge it by the scale.

Myth #8: "My smart scale tells me my exact body fat."

VERDICT: FALSE

What the evidence says: Tested against DXA scans, three smart scales were accurate for **weight**, but their fat and muscle numbers were often off by several kilograms [33].

Bottom line: Use the weight trend. Take the body-fat number with a big grain of salt. Back it up with a tape measure.

Myth #9: "Sleep doesn't matter if my diet and training are on point."

VERDICT: FALSE

What the evidence says: In two controlled studies, dieting with less sleep meant a **smaller share of the weight lost came from fat**, even when total weight loss was similar [11][31].

Evidence strength: Both studies were small. But they point the same way, and expert groups recommend 7+ hours for adults [30].

Bottom line: Protect your sleep like you protect your workouts.

Myth Verdict Summary

#	The claim	Verdict
1	Muscle burns tons of calories at rest	Misleading
2	Walking alone keeps your muscle while dieting	Misleading
3	High-protein diets hurt healthy kidneys	False (healthy adults)
4	You can't build muscle after 50	False
5	The week-one drop is all fat	False
6	The faster you lose, the better	Misleading
7	Strength training makes the scale drop faster	False
8	Smart scales give exact body fat	False
9	Sleep doesn't matter if diet and training are on point	False

Your Starter Week (Home Gear)

Here's a simple week built from the five exercises above. It hits the federal guideline of **2+ strength days** and keeps you walking [5].

Gear (use what you have): a resistance band with a door anchor, one kettlebell **or** a pair of dumbbells, a sturdy chair, and a wall or counter. No gear? Use body weight and a heavy grocery bag.

Day	Focus	What to do
Mon	Strength A	Chair squat, band row, wall/incline push-up, hip hinge, carry. 1–2 sets of 8–12 reps each [23]. Carries: walk about 30–40 steps.
Tue	Walk	A brisk walk where you can talk but not sing [5]. Use Walkingout to fit short walks into your day.
Wed	Recover	Easy walk or rest. Gentle stretching. Aim for 7+ hours of sleep [30].
Thu	Strength B	Goblet squat (hold the kettlebell or a dumbbell at your chest), one-arm dumbbell row, incline push-up, kettlebell or dumbbell deadlift, suitcase carry. 1–2 sets of 8–12 reps .
Fri	Walk	Brisk walk, plus a few short walking breaks when you've been sitting a long time [18].
Sat	Strength A or play	Repeat Strength A, or do something active you enjoy: hike, bike, swim, play with the kids.
Sun	Rest + Track	Rest. Take your weekly measurements (see the checklist). Plan next week.

How hard should it feel? Finish each set with good form and feeling like you could do **a couple more reps**. Rest about 1 to 2 minutes between sets.

Balance (especially if you're older): The federal guidelines tell older adults to include balance training [5]. Try standing on one foot near a counter for a few seconds per side after each strength session.

Next week: Keep the same plan. When you can beat your target reps by 1 or 2 with good form, make it a little harder [23]. Add a second set before you add more weight.

New to exercise, have a health condition, or returning from an injury? Check with your doctor first. Start with fewer sets and easier versions. That still counts.

How to Track: Your Weekly Checklist

Print this page or copy it into your notes app. Check what you did. Progress, not perfection.

Every day:

- ☐ Moved: walked or did another activity I enjoy
- ☐ Ate a protein food at each meal
- ☐ Got to bed on time for 7+ hours of sleep

This week:

- ☐ Strength trained on **2 or more days**, working all major muscle groups
- ☐ Wrote down my exercises, sets, reps, and weight or band color
- ☐ Beat at least one number from last week (a rep, a set, a heavier band, or better form)
- ☐ Walked most days; checked my step trend

Once a week (same day, same time):

- ☐ Weighed in. I'm watching the **trend**, not one day
- ☐ Measured my waist: just above the hipbones, after breathing out [13]
- ☐ Rated my energy, sleep, and mood (1–5)

Once a month:

- ☐ Took the same progress photo (same spot, same light, same clothes)
- ☐ Noticed how my clothes fit
- ☐ Checked in with myself: what's working? What will I adjust?

Red flags to bring to your doctor: You're getting noticeably weaker, feel dizzy or wiped out most days, or you're losing weight without trying.

Final Thoughts: Don't Just Get Lighter. Get Stronger.

Weight loss can provide meaningful health benefits.

But the scale doesn't tell you everything about what you're losing or what you're keeping.

If you're trying to lose excess body fat, make muscle preservation part of your plan from the beginning.

Walk regularly.

Include resistance training.

Eat enough protein.

Avoid unnecessarily aggressive dieting.

Prioritize sleep.

And track progress using more than one measurement.

You don't need to become a bodybuilder.

You need to build a healthier body that supports the life you want to live.

NO EXCUSES. Progress, not punishment.

Load the Standard. Live the Life.

Let's Start, ONE!

Join the LoadLine Fitness Community

Want practical strategies for improving your fitness, managing your weight, and building healthier habits?

Visit [LoadLine Fitness & Wellness](#) for educational resources and programs.

You can also join the conversation in our Facebook community, **Metabolic Reset with Jesse**, where we discuss movement, nutrition, recovery, and sustainable lifestyle changes.

Remember, your goals should fit your body, your health, and your lifestyle.

Don't copy somebody else's numbers. Learn the principles and build your own plan.

Read, download, and share this paper and others free at www.loadlinefitness.com/papers.

Glossary

Term	Plain-English meaning
Body composition	What your body is made of: mainly fat mass and lean (fat-free) mass.
Lean mass / fat-free mass	Everything that isn't fat: muscle, water, organs, bone minerals, and glycogen. Not the same as muscle alone [2].
Skeletal muscle	The muscles that move your body. You train them with exercise.
Glycogen	Stored carbohydrate in your muscles and liver. It's stored with water [1].
Calorie deficit	Taking in less energy than your body uses. This is what causes weight loss.
Resting energy	Calories your body burns at rest just to keep you alive.
Resistance (strength) training	Exercise that makes your muscles work against a load: weights, bands, or body weight.
Rep / set	A rep is one movement (one squat). A set is a group of reps done in a row.
Progressive overload	Slowly making your workouts a bit harder over time so your body keeps adapting [23].
Hip hinge	Bending at the hips with a flat back, like a deadlift.
Posterior chain	Muscles on the back of your body: glutes, hamstrings, and back.
RDA (protein)	The basic daily protein amount for healthy adults: 0.8 grams per kilogram (g/kg) of body weight [7]. 1 kg is about 2.2 pounds.
DXA	A low-dose X-ray scan used in research and clinics to measure fat, lean mass, and bone.
Smart scale (BIA)	A home scale that estimates body fat using a tiny electrical signal. Good for weight; rough for body fat [33].
Waist circumference	Your waist size, measured just above the hipbones after breathing out [13].
Sarcopenia	Low muscle mass and poor muscle function, more common with age [16].
GLP-1 medication	A type of prescription medicine some people use for weight loss. Ask your prescriber about it.
Meta-analysis	A study that pools the results of many studies to get a bigger picture.

At a Glance: Protect Your Muscle

THE BIG IDEA

Weight ≠ fat	Weight loss is a mix of fat, water, glycogen, and lean tissue [1][2]
Early drop	Glycogen is stored with ~3–4 parts water; week one isn't all fat [1]
Muscle at rest	~13 kcal/kg/day vs. ~4.5 for fat (about 6 vs. 2 per pound) [3]

THE 5 BEST MOVES

1. Lift 2+ days a week	All major muscle groups [5]. Lifting cut diet-related lean loss by 93.5% in older adults [4]
2. Keep walking	More daily steps are linked with lower risk of death [17]
3. Eat enough protein	More than the RDA helps keep lean mass while dieting [7]. Ask a dietitian for your number
4. Don't rush	Faster loss tended to cost more lean mass [9][10]
5. Sleep 7+ hours	Short sleep shifted loss away from fat in small studies [11][30]

TRACK THESE

Weight trend	Weekly, same conditions [32]
Waist	Just above the hipbones, after breathing out [13]
Strength	Reps, sets, load, band color [23]
Steps & energy	Walkingout can help plan your walks

THE LOADLINE WAY

TRAIN · MOVE · RECOVER · TRACK · REPEAT	NO EXCUSES. Progress, not punishment.
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Not medical advice. Talk to your doctor before making big changes, especially if you have a health condition or take medication.

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Medical and Educational Disclaimer

This article is provided for general educational and informational purposes only. It is not medical advice and should not replace individualized guidance from a qualified healthcare professional.

Weight loss, exercise, and nutrition needs vary based on medical history, medications, physical abilities, and other factors. Consult your healthcare team before making significant changes, particularly if you have chronic medical conditions, injuries, or exercise limitations.

Further Reading

- [CDC: Adult Activity: An Overview](#)
- [Physical Activity Guidelines for Americans: Move Your Way](#)
- [NIH Office of Dietary Supplements: Dietary Supplements for Exercise and Athletic Performance](#)
- [National Institute on Aging: Exercise and Physical Activity](#)
- [NHLBI: Aim for a Healthy Weight](#)

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